

Getting Started with Claude and Obsidian

A beginner's guide for Mac and Windows

Obsidian is a free app for keeping notes as plain text files on your own computer. Claude is an AI assistant. Put them together and you get a notes system that an AI can actually read, search, and help you write in — not a chatbot you copy-paste into, but one that works alongside files you own and keep forever.

This guide gets you from nothing installed to your first note, on either a Mac or a Windows PC. It takes about 15–20 minutes.

What you'll need

A Mac or Windows PC with an internet connection.

About 15–20 minutes, uninterrupted.

A free account for Claude (claude.ai) — Obsidian needs no account at all.

Nothing to pay for. Both apps are free to use for what this guide covers.

What you're actually installing

Obsidian: where your notes live

Obsidian is a note-taking app that stores every note as a small text file on your own computer — not locked inside someone else's server. A folder of notes is called a “vault.” Notes can link to each other by wrapping a title in double brackets, like `[[this]]`, which is how Obsidian builds a web of connected ideas instead of a flat pile of documents.

Claude: the assistant that can read and write those notes

Claude is Anthropic's AI assistant. Used on its own, it's a chat window. Used through its desktop app's Code tab and pointed at a folder on your computer, it can read the files in that folder, write new ones, and edit existing ones — which is what turns an Obsidian vault from “notes you write” into “notes an assistant helps you keep.”

Why two separate apps, not one

Obsidian owns your notes: plain text files, yours forever, readable by any app, gone only if you delete them.

Claude is the assistant that works on top of those files. If you ever stopped using Claude, every note would still open perfectly in Obsidian — nothing about your notes depends on it.

Part 1 — Install Obsidian

On a Mac

- 1 Open a web browser and go to obsidian.md.
- 2 Click the purple “Download for macOS” button. The site detects your operating system automatically, so the button should already say macOS.
- 3 Open the downloaded .dmg file from your Downloads folder, then drag the Obsidian icon into the Applications folder shown in that window.
- 4 Open Obsidian from Applications (or Spotlight: press Cmd+Space, type Obsidian, press Enter). The first time, macOS may ask if you’re sure you want to open an app downloaded from the internet — click Open.

Don’t create a vault yet

Obsidian will offer to create or open a vault the moment it opens. Skip or cancel that for now — Part 3 walks through it deliberately, including where the vault should live.

On Windows

- 1 Open a web browser and go to obsidian.md.
- 2 Click the “Download for Windows” button (the site detects Windows automatically).
- 3 Open the downloaded installer from your Downloads folder and follow the prompts. It installs in a few seconds with no choices to make.

- 4 Obsidian opens automatically when the install finishes. If Windows shows a SmartScreen warning about an unrecognized app, click “More info” then “Run anyway” — this is standard for new installers that haven’t built up download history yet, not a sign anything is wrong.

Don’t create a vault yet

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Part 2 — Install Claude

You’ll use the Claude desktop app, which includes a “Code” tab — that’s the part that can open a folder on your computer and read or write files in it, rather than just chatting.

On a Mac

- 1 Go to claude.ai/download.
- 2 Click the macOS download button.
- 3 Open the downloaded file and drag Claude into Applications, the same way you did for Obsidian.
- 4 Open Claude from Applications, and sign in or create a free account when prompted.

On Windows

- 1 Go to claude.ai/download.
- 2 Click the Windows download button.
- 3 Run the installer and follow the prompts.
- 4 Open Claude, and sign in or create a free account when prompted.

A note on accounts

Obsidian needs no account at all — it just runs. Claude needs a free account (an email address is enough to start) because your conversations and settings are tied to it.

Part 3 — Create your first vault in Obsidian

A “vault” is just a folder. Obsidian doesn’t do anything special to it behind the scenes — every note inside is a plain .md (Markdown) text file you could open in any text editor. That’s deliberate: your notes are never trapped inside Obsidian.

- 1 Open Obsidian. If it doesn’t prompt you automatically, click the vault icon in the very bottom-left corner and choose “Open another vault.”
- 2 Choose **Create new vault**.
- 3 Name it something like “**My Notes**”, and choose where it’s saved. The Desktop or Documents folder is a fine place to start — you can always move it later.
- 4 Click Create. You’ll land in an empty vault with a “Welcome” note already in it.
- 5 Create your first real note: click the **new note** icon (top-left, looks like a page with a plus sign), then just start typing. Notes save automatically — there’s no save button.
- 6 Try a link: type `[]` and Obsidian will suggest note names as you type — pick one (or type a new name and it creates that note for you). That double-bracket is the one piece of syntax worth learning first; everything else in Obsidian is just typing.

The one habit worth building early

Link liberally. A note that links to three related notes is far more useful later than three unconnected notes — that web of links is most of what makes Obsidian better than a folder of Word documents.

Part 4 — Point Claude at your notes

This is the step that makes Claude more than a chat window: telling it which folder on your computer to work in.

- 1 Open the Claude desktop app and click the **Code** tab (it may also be labeled “Code” or show a folder-and-code icon, depending on your version).
- 2 Choose “Open folder” (or similar wording) and select your vault folder — the same one Obsidian created in Part 3.
- 3 Type a message like “**What files are in this folder?**” and send it. If Claude lists your notes back to you, it’s working.

What this actually gives you

Claude can now read your notes for context, create new ones, and edit existing ones when you ask it to — in plain English, the same way you’d ask a person. It never changes a file without being asked to, and anything it writes is a normal text file you can open, edit, or delete in Obsidian exactly like one you wrote yourself.

Part 5 — A first thing to try

With Claude still open on your vault folder, try asking it something like:

“Read the note I just created and suggest two things I could link it to.”

or

“Create a note called Reading List with a few books I mention, one per line.”

Then go check Obsidian — the change will already be there. That back-and-forth, editing the same files from two directions, is the whole idea.

Part 6 — Want to go further?

Once the basics feel comfortable, some people set up a more structured vault: separate space for their own freeform notes versus a hierarchy an AI assistant maintains for ongoing projects, plus a house style file so Claude follows the same conventions every session instead of being told from scratch each time. That’s a deliberate system, not something to build on day one — but if it’s of interest later, ask whoever shared this guide with you about the “Second Brain” setup, or ask Claude directly to help you design one once you’re past the basics here.

Quick glossary

Term	What it means
Vault	A folder of notes that Obsidian treats as one connected collection. Just a normal folder underneath.

Note	A single Markdown (.md) text file. One idea per note is the usual rule of thumb.
Markdown	A simple way of formatting plain text (like bold or # heading) that any text editor can read, not just Obsidian.
Wikilink	Double brackets around a note title, like [[Note Name]], that creates a clickable link to that note.
Code tab	The part of the Claude desktop app that can open a folder and read or write files in it, instead of just chatting.

If something doesn't work

- Obsidian won't open on Windows and shows a security warning: click "More info," then "Run anyway." This is standard for a newly downloaded installer.
- Mac says the app is from an "unidentified developer": right-click the app in Applications, choose Open, then confirm — this is only needed the first time.
- Claude's Code tab can't find your notes: double-check you opened the same folder Obsidian created, not a different one, and that you selected the folder itself rather than a file inside it.
- A note you expected to see in Obsidian isn't there after Claude created it: click into the file explorer pane on the left and refresh, or close and reopen the vault — Obsidian usually picks up new files immediately, but occasionally needs a nudge.